



The Soviet endgame

The Cold War saw the buildup of thousands of tanks in Europe. Countries of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) manufactured tanks that tended to have a technological edge over the more numerous, but simpler, Soviet bloc tanks. The performance of Soviet-built tanks in conflicts in the Middle East and other regions gave the West and NATO a comforting sense of the superiority of their equipment: individually, the tanks of the West often beat the technical specifications of the Eastern bloc vehicles. However, Soviet high command's operational plan was based on many thousands of tanks from the Red Army and satellite countries—such as these Hungarian T-72s—sweeping West in vast numbers, with air and infantry support.

To face this threat, Western powers looked for examples of a smaller, highly trained, and technically superior force holding off a larger but less sophisticated force. As a result, NATO commanders visited the World War II battlefields of Normandy, France, on “staff rides” to try and learn lessons on how the smaller German tank forces held off the Allies’ armor. Fortunately, the Cold War never became “hot,” and the lessons from Normandy were not put to the test.

Hungarian tank crewmen operate Soviet T-72s during maneuvers in Tata, northwest Hungary, in 1990.